just one name. Nabin's predecessor, J.P. Nadda, who completed six years in office on January 20, passed on the baton in a ceremony that bore all the hallmarks of BJP discipline and symbolism. Indeed, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in a rare moment of humility, described Nabin as his new "boss", a "millennial with youthful energy and vast experience". "When it comes to party matters, *maananiya* (honourable) Nitin Nabinji...I am a worker, and you are my boss," the PM said in his speech. The message was clear, especially to the veterans—they would be wise to let go of any leftover rancour at young Nabin taking over the top job. The optics was also unmistakable, a generational handover was under way, even if the Modi-Shah duo still held the keys.

Party sources say Nabin was handpicked by Modi after a rigorous procedure, which only key people knew about. A 100-candidate list was whittled down to 41 after leadership skillsets/ideological moorings were ascertained via assignments. Nabin's name emerged on top after a further narrowing down which included Intelligence clearances and such. On December 12, Union home minister Amit Shah met RSS sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat at an event in Port Blair where the latter was informed about the party's choice.

BAPTISM BY FIRE

For Nabin, this is both a monumental ascent and a baptism by fire. He inherits a party at the peak of its electoral dominance but facing new kinds of fatigue, within the organisation, among the cadre and across its voter base. He will be the first president whose career map has hitherto been confined to the BJP; he has not worked directly with any of the apolitical affiliates of the Sangh. Nabin's only national forays were as general secretary of the party's youth wing, the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha; besides being election in-charge for Sikkim and co-incharge for Chhattisgarh in 2023.

A FRESH PERSPECTIVE

The new BJP chief has a proven record, and could be presiding over a momentous time for the party

Nitin Nabin has a few firsts going for him. The youngest BJP president at 45 (in fact, he was born after the party was formed in April 1980), he also got into active politics in the post-Babri Masjid demolition era when the ascent of Modi had begun in the BJP. He is also the first person from Bihar to lead the party.

Coming to the state, Nabin was just 26 when he first became MLA from Patna West (inheriting his late father Nabin Kishore Sinha's seat), going on to win Bankipur (the seat after delimitation) four more times consecutively.

The BJP president's tenure is for three years, so Nabin will finish his term in January 2029, just months before the next Lok Sabha election. The next three years are critical for the BJP. For one, a spate of state assembly elections await. Nabin has big shoes to fill; his predecessor J.P. Nadda took the party to wins in 30-plus state elections during his time. Then, of course, there is the possibility that he may also preside over a generational change of guard at the top....

NABIN MUST MAKE SPACE FOR INDEPENDENT DECISION-MAKING WHILE RESPECTING THE INVISIBLE RED LINES THAT COME WITH MODI'S LEGACY AND THE LONG SHADOW OF THE SANGH

His first, paramount test will be to manage continuity and ensure there are no shocks to the system in the transition period. It will not be easy. A series of difficult assembly elections—in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala where the BJP and allies are mounting a challenge, and in Assam and Puducherry where anti-incumbency will be a big factor—are up in just months.

Compared to that, the BJP's internal contradictions may seem more manageable. For one, the national apparatus remains heavily centralised; Modi and Shah have shaped party culture around strict loyalty metrics; decisions cascade top down. For Nabin to lead effectively, he must show that acquiescence can coexist with autonomy. He will need to make space for independent decision-making in appointments, campaign strategies and state-level negotiations, all the while respecting the invisible red lines that come with Modi's legacy and the long shadow of the Sangh. It's a delicate dance between deference and assertion. In the past, Shah and Nadda carefully looked for cues and played to their respective strengths.

Striking an equilibrium between the ideological parent's expectations and the BJP's growing appetite for power management will also be an